

British *Do*: v-Stranding Ellipsis?

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This paper experimentally investigates the “British *do*” construction, illustrated in (1) (Baker 1984, Oger 2019, Thoms 2019: 1032–1038).¹ Following a finite auxiliary with a nonfinite form of *do* in verb phrase ellipsis is ungrammatical in American English.

- (1) a. Alice will bring snacks, and Bert will **do**, too.
b. I’m not sure if Alice brought snacks, but she may have **done**.

§1 provides background on analyses locating British *do* in the verb phrase. §2 presents new experimental evidence from voice mismatches and argument structure mismatches which support treating British *do* ellipsis as eliding VP. Previous suggestions that British *do* is incompatible with voice mismatches (Lewis 2022) were not confirmed. §3 reexamines several analyses of the structural position of *do*—including a previously unexplored hypothesis that British *do* realizes (active) Voice—in light of the results from §2.

1 British *do* in the verb phrase

A prominent approach has been to analyze British *do* as realizing “little v,”² the head in the extended projection of the verb phrase that marks the verbal environment. First, examples such as (1b), where *do* follows *may* and perfective *have*, provide

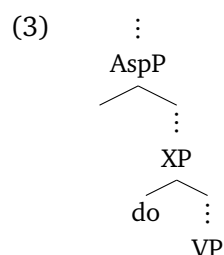
¹All examples use British English unless indicated otherwise. In what follows I will use ‘British *do*’ as shorthand for British English *do* in the British *do* construction. As is common in this literature, I use ‘British (English)’ broadly to include dialects across the British Isles. Thanks to Alice Corr, Amit Ginbar, Terry Goetz, Anya Saliy, Sascha Sturgeon, Gary Thoms, and the indomitable Amelia Combes for discussion and assistance with the data.

²See Chalcraft 2006, Haddican 2007, Aelbrecht 2010, Thoms 2011, Baltin 2012, Thoms & Sailor 2018, Griffiths & den Dikken 2022. I return to theoretical roles posited for v shortly.

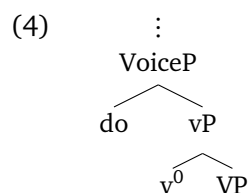
evidence that British *do* is under aspectual auxiliaries (cf. [Aelbrecht 2010: 196](#)). From the other direction, examples such as (2) suggest that British *do* isn't a main verb *V* (cf. [Stroik 2001: 364–365](#)). As the antecedent of the *wh* object of *do* is a VP (*buy candy*), *do* must occupy a position higher than such a VP.

(2) Bert might buy candy, which he shouldn't do.

Such data have been used as evidence that British *do* is under the position of aspectual auxiliaries and above VP, as reflected in (3).³



It is common at this point to identify XP with vP and assume that British *do* realizes *v* (n. 2). However, an alternative hypothesis is that British *do* realizes Voice—the head above *v* in the verbal extended projection—as in (4).



Such an analysis has not been considered in the literature. Yet it is not without merit. First I briefly outline the assumed V-v-Voice structure for verb phrases.

It is common in light of substantial morphosyntactic and semantic evidence to analyze the verb phrase as a sequence of layered projections (see [Harley 2017](#) for an overview). In addition to the lexical verb *V* (or root $\sqrt{\text{ }}$), the literature distinguishes

³I will assume an analysis of British *do* involving ellipsis and deletion of the material that goes unpronounced. Examples such as (i)–(ii) involving extraction of VP-internal arguments raise difficulties for analyses of *do* as a deficient proform that lacks internal structure (as in [Haddican 2007](#)). See [Aelbrecht 2010](#), [Thoms 2019](#), [Griffiths & den Dikken 2022](#), [Lewis 2022](#) for discussion.

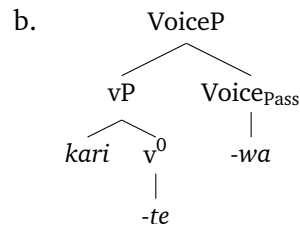
(i) Alice might fall, and Bert might do, too.

(ii) Alice might seem to like you, and Bert might do, too.

an element *v*, which marks the verbal environment, and Voice (or *v**), which closes off the verb phrase and, in a phase-based syntax (Chomsky 2001, 2008), marks the edge of the verbal phase. In (5a) the verb ‘work’ is overtly decomposed into a lexical core, here *barg*, and a verbalizing element *v*, /a/. Voice morphology may also be overt, as in (6) (Hiaki is head-final).

- (5) a. *bargat* (‘work’ (v.))
 b. *bargu* (‘work’ (n.)) (Julien 2015: 6; North Sámi (Uralic))

- (6) a. Aman kari-te-wa.
 there house-v⁰-PASS
 ‘Houses are being built there.’ (Harley 2013: 53; Hiaki (Uto-Aztecan))



I will follow Baltin (2012) and many others in the present literature and assume the three-layered architecture in what follows. I assume in particular that (i) there are projections of both *v* and Voice (in British English); (ii) *v* marks the verbal environment and hosts heads introducing (e.g.) agentive or stative semantics; (iii) Voice heads the verbal phase and hosts active and passive voice heads.

Analyzing British *do* in Voice has several *prima facie* features. First, it provides a new explanation of the observed incompatibility of British *do* with passive *be*.⁴

- (7) *John might be visited by Sally, and Fred might be done____, too.
 (Baltin 2012: ex. 20a)

⁴No occurrences are reported in Oger’s (2019) analysis of British *do* from the spoken British National Corpus. While the incompatibility of British *do* with passive *be* is well documented, few accounts offer explanations (see Baltin 2012: 399, 411–415; Lewis 2022: 5). Thoms & Sailor (2018) report that British *do* is compatible with other “passive-like structures” (Thoms 2019: 1032n.19), as in (i)–(ii) with *get* and Scottish *need*. I leave open how such constructions should be analyzed.

- (i) The cookies definitely won’t get eaten, but the cakes might do.
 (ii) The car doesn’t need washed now, but it will do by Tuesday. (Scottish English)
 (Thoms & Sailor 2018: 149n.5)

Suppose that British *do* realizes an active Voice head. Its incompatibility with passive *be* follows from its featural specification.

Second, a distinguishing feature of British *do* (versus, say, *do so/it*) is its compatibility with various types of antecedents and syntactic configurations (Baker 1984, Haddican 2007, Aelbrecht 2010, Baltin 2012, Oger 2019). In (8)–(10) we see British *do* occur with agentive, non-agentive dynamic, and stative antecedents, and in transitive, unaccusative, and unergative configurations.

- (8) Magneto/A hurricane would destroy the town, and Joker/a tornado might do, too.
- (9) Alice won't fall/dance, but Bert might do.
- (10) Meat will cost too much, but beans shouldn't do.

British *do* isn't restricted to a particular "flavor" of *v*. This flexibility may be understood in terms of an absence of selectional restrictions. The Voice head realized by British *do* doesn't select for a particular *v* head.

The previous features needn't be unique to an analysis of British *do* as realizing active Voice. For instance, regarding (8)–(10), one could posit that although British *do* is categorially specified as *v*, it is unspecified for features such as [dynamic], [trans], etc. What is important for present purposes is that a Voice-based analysis of British *do* warrants further investigation. In that spirit, the remainder of the paper begins testing *v*-based versus Voice-based analyses experimentally by investigating the ellipsis site of the British *do* construction. I focus on alternations in voice and argument structure.

2 Experiments: Mismatches under British *Do* Ellipsis

2.1 Background

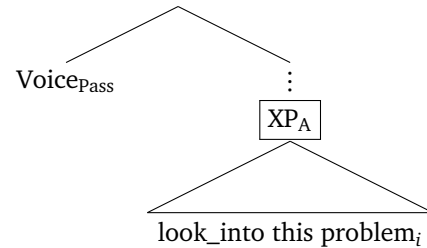
Traditional verb phrase ellipsis (VPE) tolerates various mismatches between the elided verb phrase and its antecedent. In (11) the antecedent-containing clause is passive, while the ellipsis-containing clause is active. (Angled brackets indicate the understood elided material.)

- (11) This problem was to have been looked into, but obviously nobody did.
 ⟨look into this problem⟩ (Merchant 2013: ex. 2j)

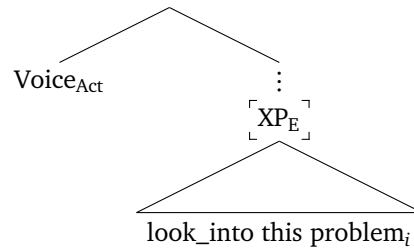
Merchant (2013) appeals to such mismatches in voice as evidence that VPE targets a phrase under Voice. Consider the rough analysis in (12). The contrasting Voice

heads are external to the antecedent and elided phrases (labeled XP_A , XP_E), hence not part of the material that needs to be relevantly identical for ellipsis to be licensed.

- (12) a. This problem_i was to have been ...



- b. ... nobody did ...



To probe whether the XP is vP or VP, Merchant considers mismatches in argument structure, as illustrated in (13) with *freeze*. In the first sentence *freeze* occurs in an unaccusative structure in which *this* raises to subject position; in the second sentence *this* occurs as object of *freeze* in a transitive structure.

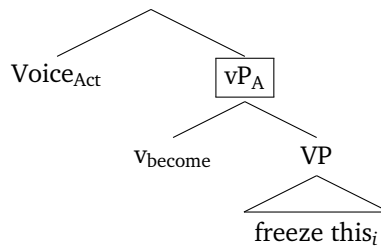
- (13) This can freeze. Please freeze this.

Such argument structure mismatches are not found under VPE ((14)). This is expected if (i) transitive and unaccusative structures have different v heads (§1), and (ii) VPE targets vP, as reflected in (15). The mismatching v heads violate the identity condition on ellipsis. (To fix ideas I represent the object in VP, and I use v_{become} and v_{cause} for the different v heads.)

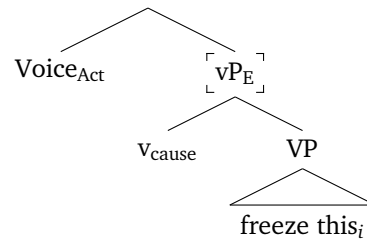
- (14) This can freeze. *Please do.

(Merchant 2013: ex. 30a, following Johnson 2008: ex. 23)

- (15) a. This_i can



b. *Please do



Suppose Merchant’s approach to mismatches under ellipsis is correct. First, if British *do* realizes *v* and VP elides, argument structure mismatches should be grammatical. The contrasting features in *v* are external to the ellipsis site and don’t bear on the identity condition on ellipsis. But if British *do* realizes Voice and vP elides, argument structure mismatches should be ungrammatical. Second, in both analyses, voice mismatches are expected to be possible.

The data, however, are not straightforward. Lewis (2022: 6) reports that voice mismatches with British *do* are “not tolerated,” yet provides a judgment of ?? for (16). This is the only example of mismatches with British *do* that I am aware of from the literature.

- (16) ??I thought the books would have been organized by now, but it seems like nobody will do. (from Lewis 2022: ex. 35; judgment Lewis’s)

A series of experiments were conducted to get a more accurate picture of the data.

2.2 Voice mismatches

First, voice mismatches under British *do* ellipsis were examined to confirm the implication of both v-based and Voice-based analyses that *do* is inside VoiceP (§2.1). Participants were 32 native British English speakers, recruited from Prolific and the University of Birmingham. The experiment had a 2×2 design with factors for the presence/absence of *do* in verb phrase ellipsis (i.e., British *do* vs. VPE) and the presence/absence of a voice mismatch. An example illustrating each condition is in (17). (Because of the incompatibility of British *do* with passive *be*, items with a voice mismatch used a passive antecedent and active ellipsis.)

- (17) a. Someone should look into the matter, though I doubt anyone will before the meeting. (VPE, –voice.mismatch)
 b. Someone should look into the matter, though I doubt anyone will do before the meeting. (do.ellipsis, –voice.mismatch)
 c. The matter should be looked into, though I doubt anyone will before the meeting. (VPE, +voice.mismatch)

- d. The matter should be looked into, though I doubt anyone will do before the meeting. (do.ellipsis, +voice.mismatch)

8 lexicalizations (tokens) of each sentence type (condition) were distributed among 4 lists via a Latin square procedure, so each participant saw two items for each condition. 4 orders for each list were created and pseudorandomized so that experimental items didn't appear sequentially, yielding 16 surveys in total (2 participants per survey). Each survey included the same (announced and unannounced) practice sentences, filler sentences, and attention checks. Sentences were rated on a 7-point Likert scale. Each participant's ratings (excluding practice items) were *z*-score transformed to reduce scale bias.⁵

The (*z*-score transformed) results were analyzed using a linear mixed effects model and restricted maximum likelihood (REML) fitting method. The model included item and participant as crossed random effects. *p*-values were provided using Satterthwaite approximations of degrees of freedom (lmerTest R package; Kuznetsova et al. 2017).

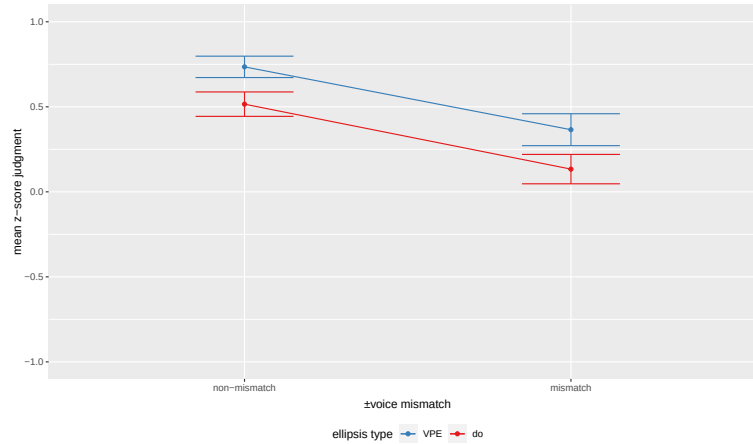
No evidence was found of a violation from voice mismatches under British *do* ellipsis (cf. (17d)). There was no interaction between voice mismatches and British *do* ($F(1, 27) = 0.005, p = .95$). (The simple effect of voice mismatches was significant ($F(1, 27) = 16.5, p < .001$), as was the simple effect of British *do* ($F(1, 27) = 5.9, p < .05$).) The mean *z*-score rating for sentences with a voice mismatch under British *do* ellipsis was also positive; the mean non-transformed rating was 5.2 (SEM = .19). An interaction plot summarizing the results is in Figure 1.

2.3 Argument structure mismatches

The results of Experiment 1 support analyzing British *do* inside VoiceP, given the Merchant-style line of argument from §2.1. A second experiment examined mismatches in argument structure under British *do* ellipsis to test the analyses of *do* in Voice versus *v*. As a reminder (§2.1), the prediction if British *do* realizes Voice and *v*P elides is that we should expect an interaction effect between *do* and an argument structure mismatch—evidence of a violation; the contrasting *v* head realizing the argument structure alternation is inside the ellipsis site. If British *do* realizes *v* and VP elides, however, per the common view (§1), argument structure mismatches under British *do* ellipsis should be grammatical.

⁵A set of unrelated “gold standard” sentences with known ratings were included among the fillers and used as a quality check to test for outliers. On this basis, two participants' responses were removed from the final analysis in Experiment 2, and three participants' responses were removed in Experiment 3.

Figure 1: British *do* & Voice mismatch interaction (Experiment 1)



The experiment had the same design and analysis methods as above, now with factors for the presence/absence of British *do* ellipsis and presence/absence of an argument structure mismatch. An example for each condition is in (18).

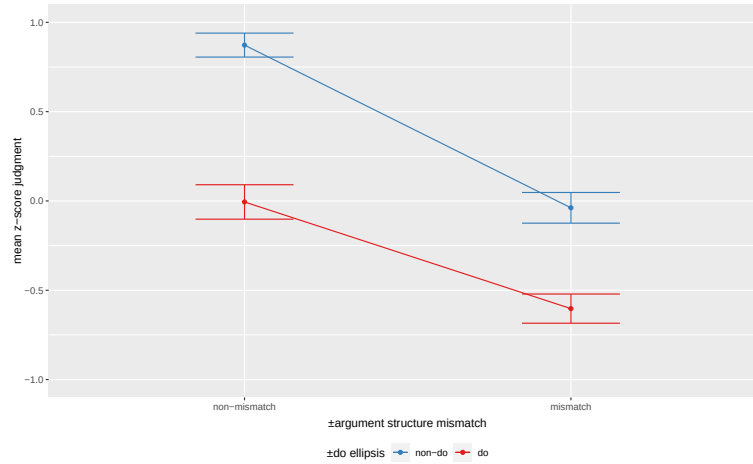
- (18) a. The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but they couldn't close it. (-do.ellipsis, -arg.mismatch)
 b. The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but they couldn't do. (+do.ellipsis, -arg.mismatch)
 c. The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but it wouldn't close. (-do.ellipsis, +arg.mismatch)
 d. The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but it wouldn't do. (+do.ellipsis, +arg.mismatch)

32 native British English speakers were recruited from Prolific to participate (n. 5).

The results failed to indicate a violation in sentences with an argument structure mismatch under British *do* ellipsis (cf. (18d)). There was a significant simple effect of British *do* ellipsis ($F(1, 27) = 53.8, p < .0001$) and a significant simple effect of argument structure mismatches ($F(1, 27) = 58.8, p < .0001$), but their interaction was not significant ($F(1, 27) = 2.4, p = .13$). An interaction plot summarizing the results is in Figure 2.⁶

⁶Although the mean rating for sentences of the type in (18d) was marginal, the difference from the baseline (cf. (18a)) was in keeping with the negative effects of an argument structure mismatch

Figure 2: British *do* & Argument structure mismatch interaction (Experiment 2)



The results from Experiment 2 were substantiated by a third experiment, which compared argument structure mismatches under British *do* ellipsis versus VPE. The experiment had a $2 \times 2 \times 2$ design with factors for the presence/absence of ellipsis, *do*, and an argument structure mismatch. The rest of the setup was the same, though with 8 sentence types (illustrated in (19)), 32 surveys, and 64 participants recruited from Prolific (n. 5).

- (19) a. The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but they couldn't (do) close it.
 b. The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but it wouldn't (do) close.
 c. The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but they couldn't (do).
 d. The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but it wouldn't (do).

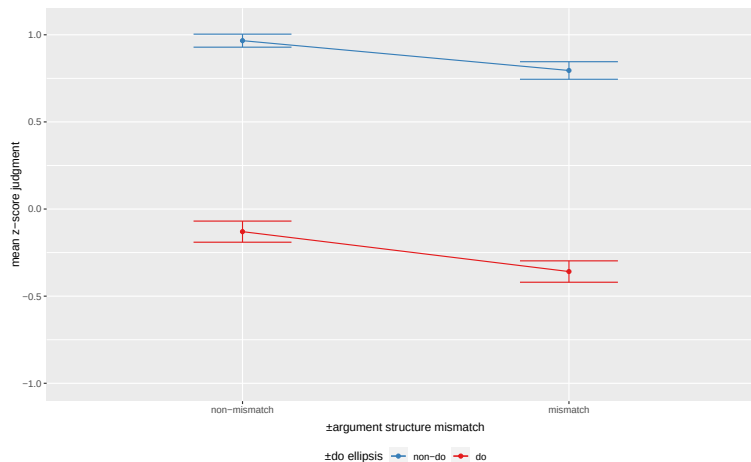
Linear mixed effects models were used to analyze the complete set of responses and the data subsets for VPE (i.e., excluding responses for the variants in (19) with *do*) and for British *do* ellipsis (i.e., excluding responses for ellipsis conditions without *do*).

As in Experiment 2, the results failed to indicate a violation in sentences with an argument structure mismatch under British *do* ellipsis (cf. (18d)). The simple effects of British *do* ellipsis and of an argument structure mismatch were again significant ($F(1, 56) = 274.0, p < .0001$; and $F(1, 56) = 8.4, p < .01$, respectively), but their

and of British *do* ellipsis. The mean *z*-score rating for the baseline sentences with British *do* ellipsis (cf. (18b)) was itself 0.

interaction was not ($F(1, 56) = 0.2, p = .67$). A plot summarizing the results from the British *do* ellipsis data subset is in Figure 3.

Figure 3: British *do* & Argument structure mismatch interaction (Experiment 3)



In contrast, the results supported the informal judgments from the literature indicating a violation in sentences with an argument structure mismatch under VPE (cf. (14), (20)).

(20) *The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but it wouldn't.

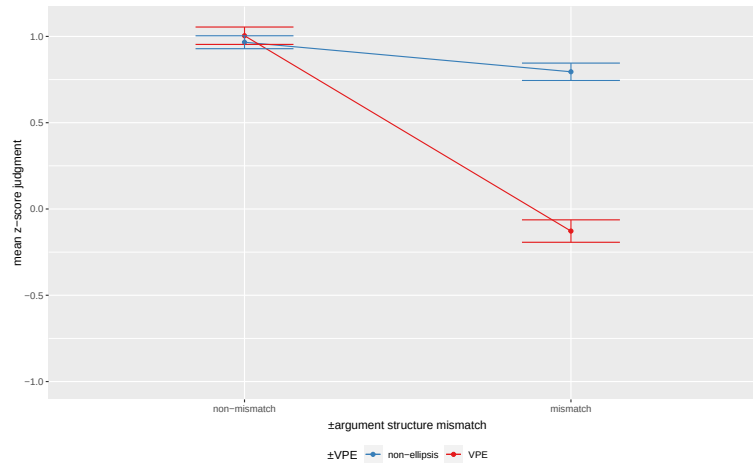
The interaction between VPE and an argument structure mismatch was significant ($F(1, 57) = 35.4, p < .0001$). (The simple effect of VPE was significant ($F(1, 57) = 31.5, p < .0001$), as was the simple effect of an argument structure mismatch ($F(1, 57) = 64.5, p < .0001$).) A plot summarizing the results from the VPE data subset is in Figure 4.

Further, analysis of the complete data set showed the interaction effect between ellipsis and an argument structure mismatch to depend on the presence/absence of *do*. The three-way interaction was significant ($F(1, 118) = 9.5, p < .01$). This provides additional evidence for a violation in the one case (VPE) and not the other (British *do* ellipsis).

3 Discussion

The experiments described in §§2.2–2.3 provide evidence that British *do* ellipsis elides VP. First, Experiment 1 failed to indicate a grammaticality violation in voice

Figure 4: VPE & Argument structure mismatch interaction
(Experiment 3)



mismatches under British *do* ellipsis, as in (17d) reproduced in (21). The idea that voice mismatches are “not tolerated” with British *do* (Lewis 2022: 6), in the sense of being ungrammatical, was not substantiated.

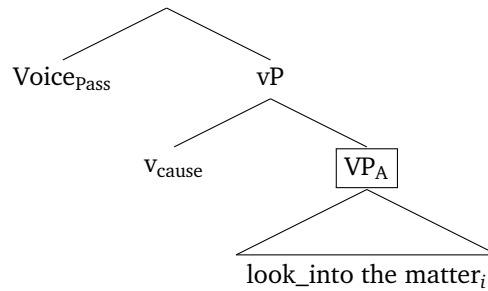
- (21) The matter should be looked into, though I doubt anyone will do before the meeting.

Experiments 2–3 also failed to indicate a violation in argument structure mismatches under British *do* ellipsis, as reflected in (22).

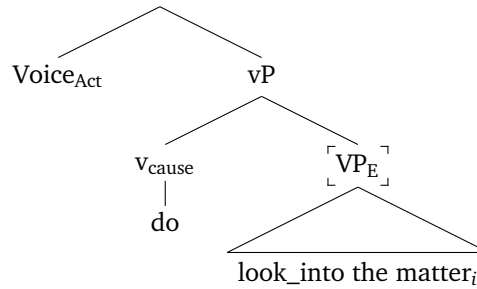
- (22) The travellers tried to close the suitcase, but it wouldn’t *(do).

The grammaticality of argument structure mismatches and voice mismatches under British *do* ellipsis is expected if the ellipsis site is VP, under vP and VoiceP—again given the assumptions from §§1–2.1 that the identity required for ellipsis is sensitive to syntax, that voice alternations are regulated (partly) by different Voice heads, and that transitive/unaccusative alternations are regulated (partly) by different v heads. In neither voice mismatches nor argument structure mismatches is the head regulating the alternation—Voice or v, respectively—in the ellipsis site. Assuming, as is common, that British *do* is sister to the ellipsis site, this places British *do* in v, as reflected in (23)–(24). (I leave open where external arguments originate.)

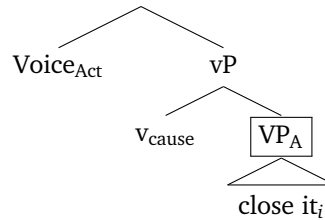
(23) a. The matter_i should be ...



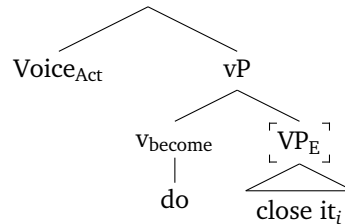
b. ... anyone will ...



(24) a. The travellers tried to ...

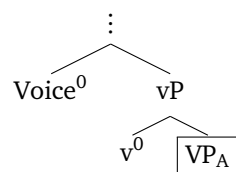


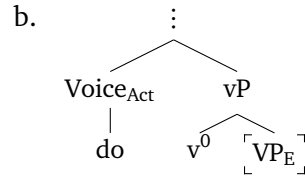
b. but it_i wouldn't ...



One might wonder what excludes an analysis in which VP elides and British *do* is in Voice, as schematized in (25).

(25) a.

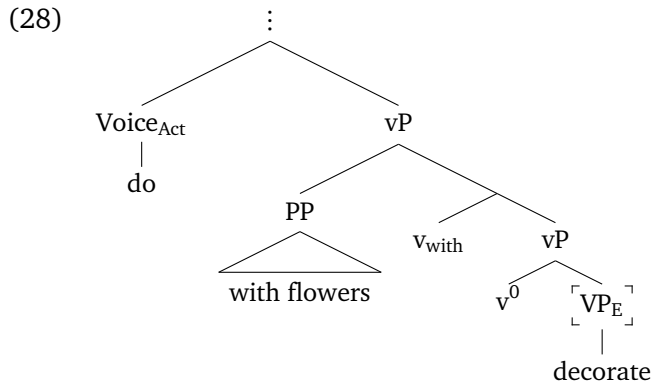




Absent further constraints, this alternative analysis predicts that British *do* should be able to co-occur with overt material in vP above the ellipsis site. This prediction is not borne out, assuming that some non-external arguments are introduced in the vP layer. British *do* cannot be followed by the direct object or oblique objects in (26)–(27). A structure such as (28) is illicit.

(26) I'm not sure if they decorate (cakes) with flowers, but they might do (*cakes/*with flowers).

(27) I'm not sure if they baked (Pat) cupcakes, but they may have done (*Pat/*cupcakes).



As has been well observed, British *do* is incompatible with material in the verb phrase spelled out to its right (Aelbrecht 2010, Thoms 2011, Baltin 2012). This could be stipulated, though formulating the principle would require care. (For instance, one couldn't simply say that British *do* has an E-feature (Merchant 2001), which triggers ellipsis of its complement.)⁷

⁷Positing a language- or lexically-specific principle is perhaps less ad hoc than it might seem. For instance, ellipsis following light verbs in Persian is possible though non-obligatory, as reflected in (i) with *zad* 'HIT', in contrast to (ii) with British *do*. (Persian is verb-final with a basic SOV word order. Thanks to Reza Hadisi, Mohsen Moghri, and Nader Shoaibi.)

- (i) Sohrab piranâ-ro otu ne-mizane, vali Rostam (piranâ-ro otu) mizane.
Sohrab shirt.PL-OBJ iron NEG-HIT.PRES.3SG but Rostam shirt.PL-OBJ iron HIT.PRES.3SG

Let's take stock. Arguments from previous literature for treating British *do* in *v* are compatible with an alternative, previously unexplored hypothesis that British *do* realizes an active Voice head. This paper has investigated the British *do* construction experimentally to help distinguish these hypotheses. First, the results disconfirmed an idea from the literature that voice mismatches are not possible under British *do* ellipsis. Second, the results provided evidence of a contrast between British *do* ellipsis and VPE with respect to argument structure alternations: unlike with VPE, argument structure mismatches were not found to trigger a violation under British *do* ellipsis. Taken together, the results support analyzing British *do* ellipsis as eliding VP. The heads regulating voice alternations and argument structure alternations (Voice and *v*, respectively) are external to the ellipsis site, and thus needn't be identical in order for ellipsis to be licensed. If British *do* is sister to the ellipsis site, as is commonly assumed, British *do* would be in *v*. Yet the matter isn't straightforward.

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'Sohrab won't iron the shirts, but Rostam will (iron the shirts).'

(adapted from Toosarvandani 2009: 70; Persian)

- (ii) Sohrab won't iron the shirts, but Rostam will do (*iron the shirts). (British English)

Persian light verbs have been argued to realize *v* (Folli et al. 2005, Toosarvandani 2009). However, Harley (2017) argues that Persian is a *v*/Voice "bundling" language (Pylkkänen 2008), where the functions of *v* and Voice are combined in a single head and morpheme. This bundling effectively obliterates the distinction being investigated here for British *do*. More detailed comparisons across languages are worth exploring.

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